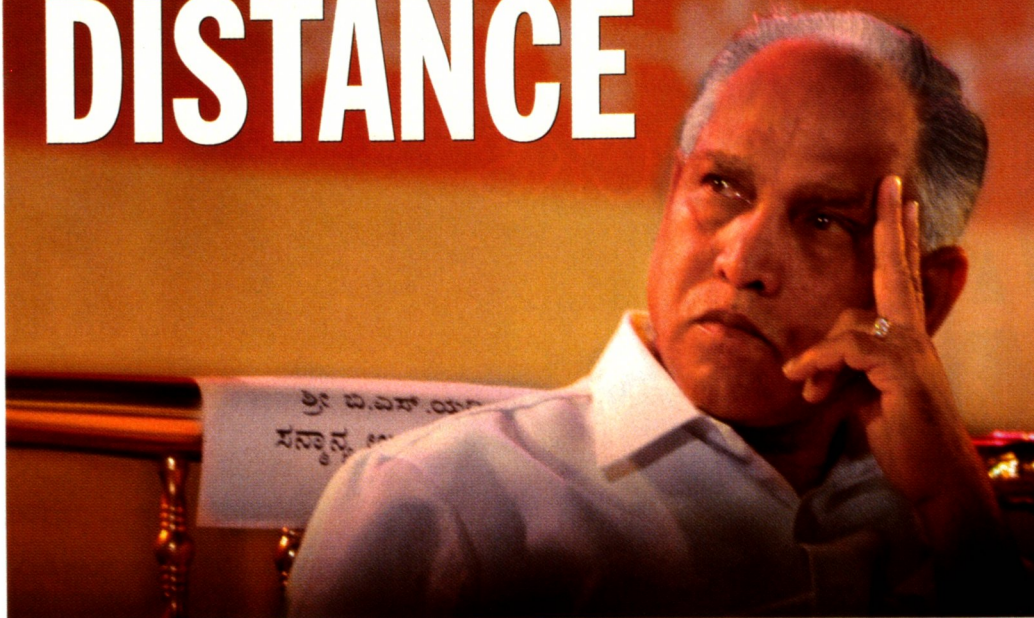


TO GO THE DISTANCE



Despite a slender majority and communal skirmishes, the chief minister aims at a long stint with focus on developmental projects

■ By Swagata Sen

In the quiet, unassuming locality of Dollar's Colony in Bangalore, a few policemen sit on a bench, discreetly keeping a watch on a one-storey house that conforms to middle-class definition. In the portico, a little girl plays while her grandfather goes through his notes for the day in office. "Not many know I live here. It helps me do my work quietly," says Karnataka's Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa. There may be time for the pomp, when the chief minister's durbar in the revamped official bungalow opens in a couple of months. But that time is certainly not now. It is a time to work from "five in the morning till midnight", to justify the slow transition from a single-storey house to the state's most important address, second only to the Vidhana Soudha.

It is a transition Yeddyurappa is just coming to terms with. When Yeddyurappa came to power in May, he was heralded as a beacon of hope that was to guide the BJP along the unknown labyrinth of south Indian politics. He was the perfect foil to Gujarat's

SLOW AND STEADY: B.S. Yeddyurappa

Narendra Modi. Many thought that the two made the ingredients of a heady combination that the BJP would use to prepare ground for E-2009. Did Yeddyurappa live up to it? Many would say he didn't.

The first crisis came with the farmer unrest in Hubli, when police firing at a peaceful rally of farmers protesting the unavailability of fertilisers killed one and injured several. The opposition parties lost no time in projecting him as anti-farmer though Yeddyurappa holds the Centre responsible for the shortage. "The Centre supplies fertiliser; we are just distributing agents," he says. He is glad that he "came out clean and strong".

In July, Bangalore became the first target of serial blasts that were to rock the nation in various cities for months thereafter. What was worse, most of the blasts were linked to Karnataka. For months, there had been signs that the SIMI was building a strong base in parts of north Karnataka. The chief minister swung into action by proposing the amendment of the Karnataka Control of Organised Crimes Act (KCOCA), revamping the state's anti-terrorist cell and demanding the return of POTA. But the damage was done.

But nothing left the Government as red-faced as the violence against Church did in

▲ The Agenda for the Bengaluru Infrastructure Development, which involves a Rs 3,000-crore road construction plan, and a Rs 1,800-crore development plan that includes 10 flyovers for the city.

▲ Free power supply for irrigation pumpsets that benefits 17 lakh farmers and cooperative loans at 3 per cent rate of interest that is expected to benefit four lakh.

▲ Construction of airports and air strips in tier II towns such as Gulbarga, Bidar, Raichur, Bagalkot, Davangere and Kushalnagar for better connectivity.

▲ A vision group called Karnataka 2020, which aims to eliminate regional imbalances, will chart the agenda for how people want to see the state 12 years from now.

▲ Power decentralisation schemes such as the Janaspandana programme, which aim at redressal of villagers' problems at the hobli level.